

Theology for the Use of Seminaries, Volume II (Mechelen 1829) — On the Virtue of Faith N. 14 (the theological conclusion and the modern Pontiff); On the Church N. 92–93 and N. 97

Peter Dens (1690–1775), Licentiate in Sacred Theology of the University of Louvain, graduate Canon and Archpriest of the Metropolitan Church of St. Rumold at Mechelen, President of the Archiepiscopal Seminary — new corrected edition, Mechelen, P.-J. Hanicq, 1829; printed pp. 283–287, 437–438, 448–450

Translated 1:1 from the diplomatic transcription. Marginal headings appear inline as {marg. ...}. Sic-notes follow the text.

BLOCK A — De Virtute Fidei, N. 14 (printed 283–287)

Is a syllogistic conclusion, which is legitimately deduced from two premises of faith, or from one premise of faith and another naturally known, of faith?

{marg. A conclusion drawn from both premises, or from one premise of faith,} R. 1. From what has already been said it is clear that, if it be considered merely as inferred through reason and a legitimate consequence, to that extent it is not believed by divine faith; but it will be an assent of theological science.

{marg. if it be considered as contained in the premise of faith,} R. 2. Such a conclusion or proposition can nevertheless be called of faith, insofar as it is considered as contained in the premise of faith; so that assent is given, not by force of the consequence, but because the conclusion is contained in the premise, and thus revealed: although[1], as Steyaert says, such faith does not properly and immediately tend toward this conclusion taken singly, but rather falls upon the premise which contains it.

{p. 284} NOTE. A conclusion can be contained in the premise *formally*, or only *virtually*.

That is said to be contained formally which is contained according to the premise's proper meaning; so that it is something identical with it, or a part of it, or an inseparable property: e.g. if I say: *Christ is man: therefore he is a rational animal; therefore he has a rational soul; therefore he is visible.*

That is said to be contained virtually, when it has such a connection with the premise that one who denies the conclusion is reckoned to deny the premise: as below in the example of Tobias's dog.

{marg. it is directly of faith, if it be contained formally.} If some conclusion is contained formally in a premise of faith, it will be directly of faith: for God, in whom there is no confused knowledge,

knows distinctly all the singulars contained under the universal, and where he reveals this universal, he speaks of all the things which are formally contained in it, and for all of them interposes his authority; therefore where it is established with a certitude beneath which no falsehood lies, that something is contained under the revealed universal, it is established that this thing is revealed in particular, and consequently pertains to faith.

Thus this syllogism: All men have sinned: but John is a man; therefore John has sinned: this conclusion, John has sinned, is contained formally in the major premise, All men have sinned, as a part of the whole expressly revealed at Rom. ch. 3 *¶*. 23, *For all have sinned, and do need the glory of God*; and therefore this proposition, John has sinned, can be said to be directly of faith.

Hence it is that many things are supposed by all to be of faith which are not explicitly revealed. Thus each of the faithful believes that he was created by God, that he contracted original sin, that he will rise again, and so forth, things which God revealed not of individuals in particular, but of all in general. So too, since it is of faith that every duly baptized infant has been justified, if I am certain that I have rightly baptized this infant, I can believe by divine faith that he has been justified. The same would hold also if God were to reveal sufficiently to someone that all the cities of Belgium were to be overthrown this year; he could {p. 285} believe by divine faith that Brussels was to be overthrown this year.

{marg. It is indirectly of faith, if it be contained only virtually.} If, however, the conclusion is contained only virtually in the revealed premise, it will be indirectly and consecutively of faith.

Thus in this argument: *Tobias's dog shewed his joy by his fawning and wagging his tail; therefore Tobias's dog had a tail*; the consequent is contained in the antecedent only virtually, not formally, the antecedent being revealed at Tob. ch. 11 *¶*. 9, *Then the dog, which had been with them in the way, ran before, and coming as if he had brought the news, shewed his joy by his fawning and wagging his tail*: because it is contained only by reason of the connection which holds between the things signified by the two propositions. And hence this proposition, *Tobias's dog had a tail*, is not of faith directly, but indirectly, namely insofar as, once it is denied, it follows that what is had at Tob. ch. 11 *¶*. 9 is false. And so, if anyone, seeing that consequence, namely that from denying that Tobias's dog had a tail it follows that a falsehood is contained in Scripture, should nevertheless pertinaciously deny it, he would be a heretic: not precisely because he denies that, but because he is convicted of pertinaciously maintaining that a falsehood is contained in Scripture. It would be otherwise if someone were to deny this without seeing that anything contrary to faith follows from it.

Hence gather how one can be said to be a heretic who maintains some proposition condemned by the Church which concerns morals only, not faith: namely, although such a one is not a heretic precisely because he maintains some proposition erroneous in morals, nevertheless, since it follows from this that the Church would have erred in condemning such a proposition, therefore the one

maintaining that proposition is convicted of being a heretic; since it is of faith that the Church cannot err in faith and morals. St. Thomas writes things conformable to this, 1 p. q. 32 a. 4, and on ch. 11 of the First Epistle to the Corinthians. See also below, N. 54.

Is it of faith that the modern Pontiff Pius VIII is the legitimate successor of St. Peter and Vicar of Christ? since it is inferred from these premises: Every Pontiff legitimately elected is the true successor of St. Peter {p. 286} and Vicar of Christ: but the modern Pontiff Pius VIII is legitimately elected; therefore he is the true successor of St. Peter, and Vicar of Christ.

{marg. It is probably of faith that the modern Pontiff is the Vicar of Christ.} R. It is plausibly maintained that this proposition, Pius VIII is the true successor of St. Peter and Vicar of Christ, is of faith; because it is contained formally in the major premise as a part in the whole, namely in this: Every Pontiff legitimately elected is the true successor of St. Peter and Vicar of Christ; which is of faith according to all. Wherefore Martin V, in the bull against the errors of Wyclif and John Hus, published in the Council of Constance, orders that one suspected of heresy be asked, among other things, « whether he believes that the Pope canonically elected, whoever he shall be for the time being, his name being expressed, is the successor of Blessed Peter, having supreme authority in the Church of God. » Coll. Conc. Hard. Tom. 8, col. 915.

Obj. Although it is of faith that every legitimately baptized infant has been justified, it is nevertheless not of faith that this infant has been justified, if it is not certainly established that he has been legitimately baptized: but neither is it certainly established that the modern Pontiff has been legitimately elected; therefore etc.

R. I deny the minor: the reason for the disparity is that whether a child has been legitimately baptized depends on the act of a private man, of which we often have no certain knowledge: whereas the legitimate election of the Pontiff rests upon the proposition of the universal Church, acknowledging the modern Pontiff as legitimate; in which matter it cannot err, lest otherwise it acknowledge as head one who is not head, and that without remedy.

{marg. Not, however, of catholic faith.} It is to be noted, however, that it is not of catholic faith that the modern Pontiff is the successor of St. Peter and Vicar of Christ: for that has not been sufficiently proposed to the whole Church with the obligation of believing. From which it is clear that there can be schism, that is, separation from subjection to the Pontiff, without heresy.

Gather when one who denies what is implicitly revealed is to be called a heretic, and when not. If the Church herself makes the deduction and proposes it, the proposition is of catholic faith, and one who denies it is a heretic; but if the Church does not make the deduction, he who does not see the consequence will not be a heretic: he, however, who {p. 287} sees it clearly will, conformably to what has been said, be a heretic in the forum of God, not in the forum of the Church. This is also the

reason why the Church, in proscribing propositions of this kind, does not condemn them as heretical, but only as erroneous, or proximate to heresy. On which see below, N. 55.

BLOCK B — De Ecclesia, N. 92–93 (printed 437–438)

Who is this successor of Peter?

R. It is of faith that he is the Roman Pontiff. This is proved from the constant definition of the general Councils and of the Church, and from the doctrine of the holy Fathers; so that St. Augustine says on that account that that succession, continuous from the very see of Peter, retains him in the Catholic Church.

This succession is continued down to the present day in a series of 255 Pontiffs.

{p. 438} N. 93. ON THE POWER OF THE SUPREME PONTIFF.

From whom does the supreme Pontiff, legitimately elected, receive his power and jurisdiction?

{marg. The Pope has his power immediately from Christ,} R. He receives it immediately from Christ as his Vicar, in the manner in which Peter received it.

Nor does it stand in the way that the Pope is elected by the Cardinals: for their election is only a *conditio sine qua non*, and once it is posited, he receives power and jurisdiction immediately from Christ.

BLOCK C — De Ecclesia, N. 97 (printed 448–450)

N. 97. CAN THE PONTIFF, AT LEAST AS A PRIVATE PERSON, BE A HERETIC?

{marg. The Pope cannot be a heretic even as a private person.} Resp. Although this would not stand in the way of the preceding conclusion, as has been said, the negative opinion is more probable, so that the privilege of Peter, concerning which Luke ch. 22 *¶*. 32, *I have prayed for thee, that thy faith fail not*, passes also to the successors of Peter: and this is consonant with divine Providence, that he who is the teacher of faith should himself not fail in faith.

It is proved also from this, that of no Pontiff hitherto has it been able to be proved that he was a formal heretic: and St. Augustine attests this in Epist. 165 concerning the Pontiffs down to his own times.

Obj. I. Marcellinus under Diocletian burned incense to idols; therefore etc.

R. St. Augustine, and after him Baronius, Bellarmine, Christian Lupus and others, say that the lapse {p. 449} of Marcellinus is a fiction invented by the Donatists: Binius, Schelstrate, and others, who admit the lapse, say that Marcellinus offered incense to idols from fear of death, and therefore sinned against the profession of faith, but did not inwardly lose the faith.

Obj. II. Pope Liberius subscribed to the formula of faith of Sirmium drawn up by the Arians, and to the condemnation of Athanasius, who was defending the true faith; therefore he was a heretic.

R. I deny the consequence: it is indeed true that Liberius was sent into exile by Constantius for the catholic faith, and at last, overcome by calamities and weariness, communicated with the Arians, and subscribed to the condemnation of Athanasius, not on account of his faith, but on account of crimes falsely alleged against him by the Arians.

Then he subscribed to the formula of Sirmium, which, although the word *consubstantial* was passed over in silence in it, contained nothing contrary to faith, even though it did not explain the faith sufficiently: from which, therefore, it cannot be proved that Liberius was a heretic, although in his manner of acting he is not excused from sin.

Meanwhile there are not lacking those who hold the lapse of Liberius to be a mere fable spread abroad by the Arians and believed, as is the custom, by some catholics. See Collet in the treatise on the Most Holy Trinity, q. 4 a. 3 q. 2.

Obj. III. Honorius I was a Monothelite; therefore etc.

The antecedent is proved: because in his Epistle to Sergius he teaches that in Christ there is one will, not two.

R. I deny the antecedent: to the proof it is said that in those Epistles he did not deny two wills in Christ, the divine and the human, but only denies two conflicting human wills, one of the flesh, the other of the spirit; such wills as we experience in ourselves, in whom, from our corrupted origin, the flesh lusts against the spirit: and he directed that the expressions of one will or of two wills be abstained from, lest from a diverse understanding of the words a schism should arise.

You will press: The Sixth Synod condemned Honorius as a heretic; therefore etc.

R. Sylvius, with certain others, holds that the acts of that synod are corrupted, and the name of Honorius substituted in place of Theodore: but Thomassin learnedly refutes this invention in dissertation 20 on the Sixth Synod.

{p. 450} Others say that the Sixth Synod erred in condemning Honorius, namely by a merely personal[2] error of fact, not concerning the literal sense of dogmatic texts: for, they say, the judgment of the synod was merely criminal, not dogmatic: for the question raised was principally about the person of Honorius; whence his Epistles were not discussed primarily so that inquiry

might be made about doctrine, but only so that the person might be judged; and in a judgment of this kind it was admitted at N. 84 that the Church can err.

Others say that Honorius was condemned in the Sixth Synod as a favourer of heresy, but not as a heretic: this opinion is favoured by the fact that Leo II, who confirmed the synod, in various places charges Honorius only with negligence and imprudence, « by which he permitted the immaculate faith to be stained »: likewise by the fact that the emperor Constantine Pogonatus, who was present at that council, condemns Honorius as a favourer, abettor and confirmer of heresy. It is indeed true that the words, Anathema to Honorius the heretic, are pronounced; but the Fathers do not seem to have distinguished between heretics and favourers of heresy: at least the very words of the Fathers charge Honorius rather with connivance than with an open profession of heresy.

Obj. IV. At Dist. 40. Can. SI PAPA it is said that the Pope judges all and is to be judged by none, unless he be found to have strayed from the faith; therefore he can be a formal heretic.

R. I deny the consequence: for it is only said what could be done in the case in which the Pontiff should fail in faith: but we think that this case has never happened, nor will happen.

Sic-notes

1. *quamquàm*, rendered “although” (printed 283 = PDF 284, in R. 2.): so printed, with a grave accent on the second syllable. Read *quamquam*. The book accents adverbs and ablatives freely, but this form is not part of that system and appears to be a compositor’s slip.
2. *personâlis*, rendered “personal” (printed 449 = PDF 451, in “Others say that the Sixth Synod erred in condemning Honorius”): so printed, with a circumflex over the second *a*. Read *personalis*. Verified at high magnification; the mark is a clear circumflex, not a speck.

Closing note

Fixed renderings. The technical vocabulary is held constant throughout: *de fide* is “of faith” and *de fide catholica* “of catholic faith”, *fide divina* “by divine faith”, *contineri formaliter / virtualiter* “to be contained formally / virtually”, and *assensus scientiæ theologicæ* “an assent of theological science”, so that the argument’s distinction between what is believed on God’s authority and what is inferred by reason stays visible in English. Scripture is given in the Douay wording, since that is the version an English reader of this manual would have used, and the versicle sign is kept as printed.

Sentence structure and connectives. Dens writes in long periods hinged on *quòd*, *cùm*, *undè* and *nimirùm*; these have been kept as single English sentences with their colons and semicolons intact rather than broken up, because the force of each answer depends on the sequence of subordinate clauses. Debate formulas are rendered by their standing English equivalents: *R. Neg. min.* as “R. I deny the minor”, *Instabis* as “You will press”, *Probatur ant.* as “The antecedent is proved”.

Latin retained. *Conditio sine qua non* is left in Latin and italicised, as it functions in English as the same term of art. Marginal glosses are translated in place at the head of their paragraphs; the first two run on as one sentence in the original and read as a continued phrase in English also.